went so far as to write a whole treatise condemning Abdun Nabi for the various death sentences he handed out to suspected blasphemers, adding, for good measure, that the shaikh was ‘undutiful towards his father, and . . . afflicted with hemorrhoids’. Abdun Nabi, writes Badauni, replied that his colleague ‘was a fool’.

All this unseemly drama gave ‘persons of novel and whimsical opinions’ the perfect opportunity to mislead Akbar into their various heterodox swamps, writes Badauni. Already, as he sees it, Akbar was far too indulgent of a Shia scholar, Mulla Muhammad of Yazd, and of his brahmin bard Birbar – ‘that bastard!’ Already, Akbar was too readily influenced by three newly arrived brothers, Sunni refugees from Shia Iran – Hakim Abul Fath, Hakim Humam and Hakim Nuruddin. The first and eldest of them, a charming and well-spoken man, was able to accommodate ‘every change in the religious ideas of His Majesty, or even went in advance of them’, so that he was soon Akbar’s ‘most intimate friend’. Already, that is, Akbar had been far too welcoming of far too many kinds of men; now, they were joined by ‘sages of various religions and sects’, each favoured with Akbar’s attention.

Now, there was the brahmin Debi, pulled up in a charpai to the emperor’s bedroom balcony, to explain ideas like the transmigration of souls; the brahmin Purushottam whom Akbar commissioned to invent Sanskrit names for ‘all things in existence’. Now, there was a Sufi called Shaikh Tajuddin similarly suspended ‘in a blanket’ to recount his ‘obscenities and follies’;[20] and, though Badauni doesn’t mention them, there were charismatic Jain and Parsi priests.

And now, there was, Abul Fazl.

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In the four-odd years since Badauni and Abul Fazl arrived in Akbar’s court, Abul Fazl’s career had progressed much faster, and certainly more happily, than Badauni’s.

Badauni was employed in Akbar’s increasingly active translation department, and he was good at his work. His first book was the *Singhasan Battisi*, ‘a series of thirty-two tales about Rajah Bikramajit king of Malwa’. Badauni was commanded to begin work immediately – a ‘learned Brahman